From Polycrisis to Metacrisis

A Short Introduction

Rufus Pollock & Rosie Bell – Life Itself Sensemaking Studio

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A Short Introduction

Rufus Pollock & Rosie Bell – *Life Itself* ***Sensemaking Studio***

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Synopsis

Our world shows signs of multi-systemic breakdown. In this context, **polycrisis** names an *entanglement* of interconnected crises that affect one another - ecological, political, cultural, technological. **Metacrisis**, by contrast, denotes foundational conditions that generate these crises. Just as symptoms signal an underlying illness, polycrisis points to metacrisis. While the reality of a global polycrisis is increasingly acknowledged, awareness of metacrisis is less common.

Noticing the interactions between our symptoms is an important step towards addressing them. However, deeper diagnosis of an issue is vital to effective strategies for healing. This introductory essay investigates how collective **worldviews**, particularly within a dominant cultural paradigm of **modernity**, lie at the root of systemic failures — and offers a number of case studies for rethinking polycrisis as symptoms of metacrisis.

Within a metacrisis frame, the deep stories foundational to our modern worldview shape our relationship to self, others and world, in ways that produce dysfunction. While its symptoms (polycrisis) can be perceived in manifest forms from climate breakdown to inequality and more, metacrisis itself can be more difficult to see: we commonly mistake the core ideas of modernity for reality itself. As such, adopting a frame of metacrisis requires more than learning new facts. To sustain the necessary shift in view can require integration through practice, community and lifestyle shift.

This essay is intended as a bite-sized introduction to the core ideas of polycrisis and metacrisis, and their relationship. We include a brief overview of leading accounts within current social philosophy, while taking responsibility for our particular interpretation (and potential simplification) of the concept. This includes a schematic sketch of metacrisis 'layers' which may help readers to make sense of interrelating crisis issues at different depths, and to navigate various existing accounts.

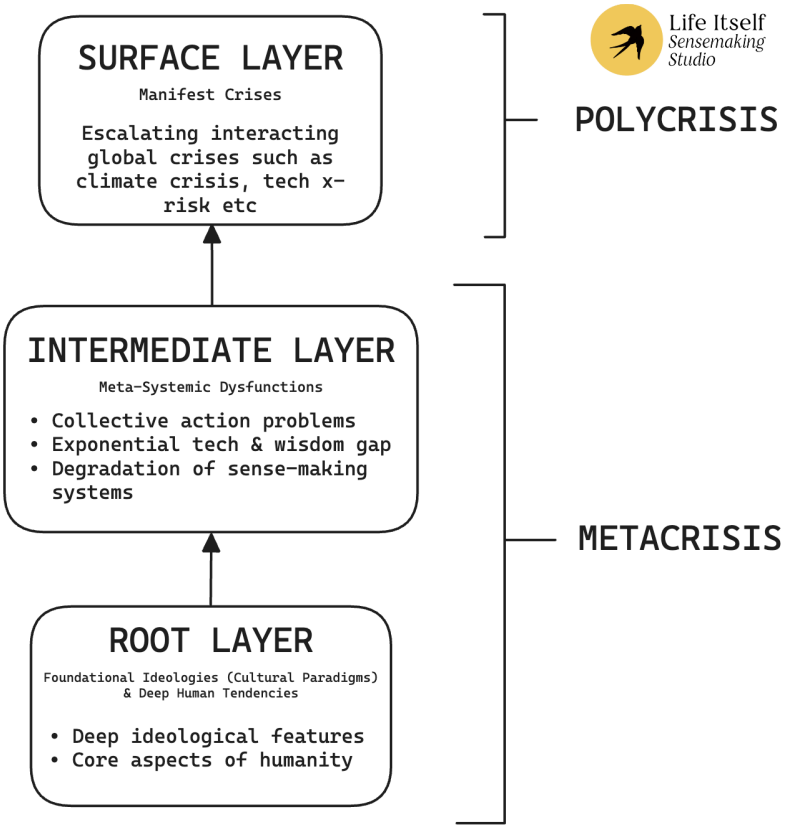

Fig 1: A simplified schematic logic of the polycrisis-metacrisis relationship.

Polycrisis symptoms share common roots in the 'meta' layers of our civilizational systems and worldviews. The discourse of metacrisis links issues in the lower two layers with emergent (surface) symptoms. Issues at all three levels affect each other at different timescales. However, the more fundamental drivers exist at the 'bottom': in deep-seated human tendencies and foundational ideologies.[1]

In short, a metacrisis is a crisis arising from the "meta" layers of civilization, and especially the cultural foundations.

[1] See page 10 ff. for more detail.

What's a polycrisis?

"A global polycrisis occurs when crises in multiple global systems become causally entangled in ways that cause major human harm. The interactions between constituent crises are significant enough to produce emergent harms that are different from, and usually greater than, the sum of the harms those crises would produce separately."

- *Cascade Institute / Lawrence et al. (2024)*[2]

"A cluster of distinct crises that interact in ways that they and/or their effects tend to reinforce each other."

- *Helleiner 2024*

Throughout the early 2020s, **polycrisis** has become a buzz-word, in a world growing aware of its vulnerability to multiple interwoven, escalating crises.[3] Increasingly, we recognize that our **proliferating global crises reinforce and amplify one another** - from ecological breakdown to economic fragility, geopolitical volatility, inequality, health threats, and the prospect of superintelligent AI with catastrophic capability.[4]

In this landscape, thanks to the wicked entanglement of causes and effects, reacting to isolated problems without considering other crises tends to produce undesirable side-effects that find their way back to our own back yard - or somebody else's. Addressing the whole seems an impossibility. Between them lies the territory of systems thinking.

Systems approaches to polycrisis seek to "anticipate and respond to cascading failures" in complex systems that lead to multidimensional threats[5] - and opportunities therein to transform towards resilient, thriving systems. Embracing complex, inter-systemic approaches is a hugely important step in dangerous times, and many skilful organisations operate within this space, supporting stakeholders to

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[2] Cascade is a leading global institute for addressing "humanity's converging environmental, economic, political, technological, and health crises."

[3] Morin & Kern (1999) first described "a "complex intersolidarity of problems, antagonisms, crises, uncontrollable processes, and the general crisis of the planet."

[4] See e.g. Heinberg & Miller (2023)

[5] E.g. Lawrence et al. (2024)

comprehend the bigger picture. Even within mainstream policymaking it's becoming more common to talk about cross-sectoral collaboration[6], and moving beyond siloes.

If one aspect of the polycrisis is easy to grasp, it's that things are getting worse. Since the early 1990s, the strategic leadership field has used the (originally military) term VUCA to reflect on the Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity and Ambiguity of conditions, and in recent decades it has become commonplace to describe a VUCA *world*. Still more recently however, analysts have advised updating that term to BANI: Brittle, Anxious, Non-linear and Incomprehensible. As the complexity of our situation escalates, our capacity for making sense of it becomes ever more inadequate.[7] From development NGOs to Davos, polycrisis breeds not only anxiety and dispute, but an insidious sense of paralysis.[8] Within a shrinking window of possibility for challenges such as climate mitigation, crises go on emerging and deepening. The systems of global civilization risk cascading collapse, threatening large-scale destruction of life.

Why do crises keep emerging?

The rising popularity of the term 'polycrisis' signals that some leaders and institutions understand the crucial importance of broadening analysis of *what* is happening, beyond sectoral siloes. However much current systemic thinking, in its focus upon the level of context and interconnections, still doesn't operate at the level of common root causes. The natural next step for applied systems thinking is towards diagnosing *why* these crises keep emerging.

The approach we need has an everyday precedent. We are accustomed to understanding collections of symptoms as representative of a deeper disease. If globalised society were a hospital patient, doctors might begin by treating the most obvious presenting symptoms. But seeing a whole body stressed in multiple ways and breaking down, they also would begin quickly to ask what underlying condition was to blame.

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[6] E.g. Crisislab (2024)
[7] E.g. Stein (2019)
[8] E.g.Leonard, 2024

In short, **while noticing symptoms is vital and treating them can limit harm, a deeper diagnosis of the underlying issue is vital to effective strategies for healing.**

Taking the same approach to our constellation of crises, we're looking for an explanatory condition which we must treat if we hope to stop symptoms from proliferating. Some social philosophers call the condition a **meta**crisis.[9]

[9] Metacrisis is an evolving arena of enquiry and we do not mean to suggest that full consensus yet exists on its definition. Appendices I and II give a sense of the emerging definition and the following sections contain additional references.

What's a metacrisis?

'Meta' as a prefix often denotes a self-referential object.[10] A study of many studies is a meta-analysis. The particular idea of metacrisis encompasses not only a crisis of many crises, but the common roots connecting the many: a foundational set of conditions that generates and maintains multiple emergent crises. It's this foundational aspect that we're most interested in here:

A metacrisis is a crisis at the foundations of a civilization, arising from its core views and values – its basic, dominant worldview or "cultural paradigm".[11]

Understanding this metacrisis is essential if we're even to begin redirecting our energies towards healing the source of our crises and restoring a stable basis for sustainable planetary civilisation. Throughout the recent decade, a number of social philosophers have worked to demonstrate how the deep structure of views and values underpinning modern civilization generates and amplifies behaviours that produce crisis symptoms.[12]

"The metacrisis…lives within us, between us and beyond us, and to some extent defines us."

– Jonathan Rowson[13]

"The metacrisis is a complex, multifaceted gestalt or "laminated system."

– Nicholas Hedlund[14]

"The metacrisis… has to do with how humans understand themselves and the world… systems and societies are in trouble, but it is the psyche that is in the direst of straits.

– Zak Stein[15]

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[10] Originally Greek: after / beyond / with.

[11] This simplified definition of metacrisis focuses particularly on root causes of crisis, in contrast to more complex 'laminate' views that encompass root causes, systemic interactions and feedback effects such as epistemic confusion - see page 11.

[12] See e.g Rowson (2024), Vervaeke, Schmactenberger, Mcgilchrist (2023) and a consolidated presentation in Life Itself / Second Renaissance (2024).

[13] Rowson (2020). See also appendices I and II.

[14] Hedlund (2023)

[15] Stein (2022)

Terminology: Cultural Paradigms, Worldviews and Values

Cultural paradigms: shared organising frameworks of meaning including assumptions about what can be known and how it should be understood.
Worldviews: core sets of beliefs about the nature of reality: what the world is, how it works and humanity's place within it. Usually informed by paradigms.
Values: deeply held beliefs about what *matters:* what is good, meaningful and desirable.

Worldviews, paradigms and values shape each other, and are always operating together within human identities, choices and behavior at individual and collective; psychological and structural levels. The phenomena are deeply interwoven and terms often used interchangeably.

Hiding in plain sight: worldview as metacrisis

Whereas symptoms are by definition easy to spot, their causes are often less visible. Of all the conditions that could be difficult to spot, our own worldview(s) may be the hardest - because this is the seemingly transparent lens that delivers our most basic perception of the world. Typically we take its organising principles for fundamental features of reality itself. Our worldview determines what we take for granted. It sets the parameters of the world we encounter — what exists and what doesn't (our ontology) and what counts as 'knowledge' (our epistemology).

While no two perspectives on the world are exactly the same, nonetheless many of the assumptions or ways of looking that we take for granted are shared with those around us; transmitted by the culture in which we live our lives and the physical and social structures that reflect them. Often the dominant views and values operating at a given time relate to a particular foundational family of ideas, mutually influenced by the stories, practices and events of a culture or era, amounting to a shared model

of reality. The dominant model(s) operating within a society throughout a particular age of history - the ways of looking shared by most of society - we can call a **cultural paradigm.**

Deep-seated views and values are often most visible to those living 'outside' them in some way. Like the fabled fish, unaware of the water it's swimming in, we usually perceive 'reality' without awareness of the shared mental models that shape it within our own perception.[16] So we commonly neglect their importance when diagnosing our own societal challenges. Nonetheless from a view that understands that cultural paradigms *are* always operating, we may begin to see how a warped and/or outdated societal lens could produce behaviours that lead to crisis.

Paradigm transition

Throughout human history, core cultural paradigms have shifted over long periods of time, seeded by revolutions in thought and empowering new perspectives, and accelerated by collapse or failure in the previous social organisation. Paradigms can last for centuries, their enduring features persisting long after new paradigms have become dominant. Consider for example the way in which organised religion succeeded myth as a source of our ultimate knowledge and instruction, gradually to be succeeded in turn by rational-scientific modernity.[17]

[16] In this regard cognitive science is congruent with Buddhism, which identifies **unconscious attachment to particular views** as core to all human suffering.

[17] Appendix V discusses the conditions surrounding paradigm shift as a source of cultural crisis

The modern worldview

There is a sense in which we no longer live in a world at all, but exist in a simulacrum of our own making."

- Iain McGilchrist[18]

Throughout the **modern** age, a cultural paradigm rooted in the embrace of empiricism, reductionism and rationalism has come to dominate a globalised, market-based civilisation.[19] Over the four centuries since the European 'Enlightenment', modernity has driven extraordinary scientific progress; delivering unprecedented material comfort to many. At the same time, it has fostered a mass culture of alienation and exploitation, ultimately setting globalised civilisation on a trajectory for collapse. Modernity's gifts carried a grievous cost, and like every other cultural paradigm, it ultimately contains the seeds of its own decline. Most theorists of the metacrisis identify our root condition with the dying paradigm and / or its manifestations in particular systemic effects and behaviours.

While we offer the simplified metaphor of a root cause in order to introduce the idea of metacrisis, we would guard against a too-linear or singular sense of coming first or before. Systems of knowledge, ways of life, structures and institutions built on modern principles reproduce our metacrisis throughout daily life.[20] In turn, these structures direct and reinforce culture over time; shaping our shared sense of reality and the deep ideas that constitute it.

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[18] Mcgilchrist (2024)

[19] Appendix II offers a basic guide to some prominent features of modernity.

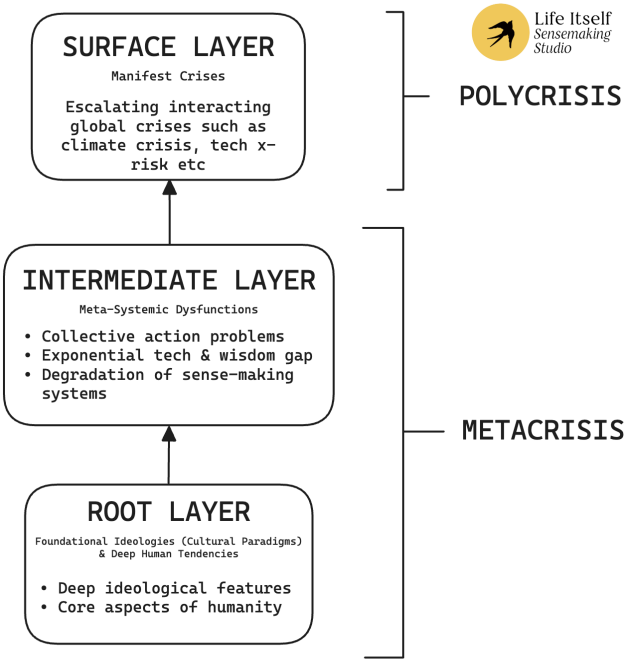
[20] Rowson (2023) describes a condition "within and between all the world's major crises…a multi-faceted delusion arising from the spiritual and material exhaustion of modernity".

From Polycrisis to metacrisis - three 'layers'

The diagram below outlines the relationship of polycrisis to metacrisis, offering a simplified conceptual layering of complex interacting causes.

1. Polycrisis describes societal symptoms at the 'surface' level - global crises from ecological collapse to AI risks and geopolitical instability - and interacting failures of sense-making.

2. These pathologies can be interpreted as emerging from an intermediate layer of **Meta-systemic dysfunctions** - identifiable complexes of structural and cultural factors that reliably lead to harm.[21] For example: collective action failures (tragedies of the commons such as inaction on climate, regulatory capture, perverse incentives / race-to-the-bottom dynamics. 'Wisdom gap' between escalating technological capacity and moral/epistemic maturity. Epistemic fragmentation; breakdown of collective intelligence[22]



3. These intermediate dysfunctions are in turn rooted in **deeper cultural-ideological and psychological substrates**. The root layer of our crises consists of foundational ideologies (cultural paradigms) interacting with deep human tendencies. For example:
- Core ideological features of modernity such as anthropocentrism, individualism, mechanistic reductionism, rationalism,

[21] In Daniel Schmachtenberger's language, 'generator functions'. Similar to 'failure modes' in systems thinking.
[22] E.g. Schmachtenberger 2017, Schmachtenberger 2020

- Potential[23] human tendencies such as greed, fear and control, amplified by systemic factors.

These foundational features don't *cause* the polycrisis directly, but predispose systems toward tendencies such as fragmentation, extractivism and so on, that drive symptoms. Furthermore, their relationship to other layers is non-linear. While it makes sense to understand shared worldviews as directly foundational to structures and behaviors (including institutions and technologies),[24] over time structures and behaviours likewise shape worldviews and cultural paradigms, and even our innate psychological tendencies.

From polycrisis to metacrisis: three case studies

Polycrisis symptoms express core features of the modern paradigm in myriad ways. Here we offer just a handful of highly simplified 'case studies'.

It should be stressed that the relationships between these factors are far more complex than suggested here. Likewise bear in mind that not all of these beliefs and attitudes *originate* in modernity in any simple way. Rather, all are implicit within human nature and maintained or 'up-regulated' by modernity: the widespread dominance of modern narratives, behaviours and practices has cemented their status as foundations of our shared reality, while deprioritising other important ways of looking.[25]

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[23] 'Potential' is important - to say that greed is a fundamental human tendency is not to say that humans are fundamentally greedy—or at least not *only.* We are also fundamentally collaborative and capable of self-sacrifice, and which of these qualities comes to the fore depends greatly on the cultural environment that amplifies or restrains them

[24] See e.g. Meadows (1999) and Hedlund (2023)

[25] Iain McGilchrist's (2010) account of dysfunction in modern society as manifestation of a particular worldview is influential throughout metacrisis thought.

Case study 1: climate breakdown

"The metacrisis is a profound misunderstanding of the nature of of what is valuable."

- Zak Stein[26]

Polycrisis framing sees climate change as an escalating crisis interconnected with biodiversity loss, food security, economic instability, and migration. Its principal challenge is the complex inter-governmental task of decarbonising global energy use while maintaining stability in these adjacent areas.

Metacrisis framing looks to modern excesses of **reductionism, materialism** and **rationalism** underpinning all of these conditions:

- At their core, a reductive metaphor of **world-as-machine**, entrenched by industrial revolution, has led to widespread misunderstanding of complex living systems as predictable mechanisms, no more than the sum of their **separate** parts.
- Courtesy of a misplaced Darwinian ethos, the related quest for human **dominance over nature**[27] has encouraged modern societies to **exploit and extract** from the web of life that we belong to as if it were separate to ourselves.[28] Harm to others and the natural world is dismissed as '**externality**'.
- **Secular materialism** has disenchanted and devalued the living, natural world while producing an endemic thirst for meaning that manifests in runaway consumerism. The dominant measure of the human good is gross domestic product, a measure of material goods bought and sold.[29]
- **Market fundamentalism** is predicated on an outdated modern model of humans as **rational** agents; choosing desirable outcomes on the basis of their own best interests. Human biases, heuristics and emotional decision-making

[26] Stein (2024)

[27] Establishing an "empire of man over creation" in the words of Francis Bacon.

[28] See e.g. Kingsnorth (2018)

[29] The UK's Labour leadership demonstrates ongoing inability to understand the foundational relationship of ecological stability to economic stability. See e.g. Stewart (2025)

are excluded from an economic model focused on endless **material growth**, consuming the earth unimpeded.

- A profound **future orientation** or **myth of progress** has associated the quest for a good life with resource-hungry **technological advancement** and fatally deprioritised both ancient wisdom and the more-than-human world.
- **Empirical** fixation on the material and measurable has led to gross devaluation of unmeasurable value, which is destroyed at a mass scale to create financialised value.[30]
- This same fixation underpins widespread ignorance and de-prioritisation of the **inner** world, fuelling consumerism thanks to an ensuing meaning crisis, **and ensuring that mindsets and worldviews are not considered when formulating the climate problem and seeking solutions.**

When it comes to *addressing* the climate crisis through approaches such as global decarbonisation, the same core narrative of **separateness** generates a collective action problem that prevents the necessary collaboration. Seemingly separate interests incentivise nations to shirk the collective task because their sense of belonging to the whole, including the natural world and other human populations, is radically deprioritised. Meanwhile they pursue competitive priorities of infinite growth in economies dependent on the health of a finite natural resource.

Case study 2: Runaway AI.

"As technology is empowering our choices and we are getting something like the power of gods, you have to have something like the love and the wisdom of gods to wield that or you self-destruct."
— Daniel Schmachtenberger

Acceleration and mainstreaming of Artificial Intelligence technologies has led to growing anxiety around the potential threat that exponential AI could pose in the longer term. AI has already begun to corrode the information commons through e.g.

[30] See e.g Life Itself / Stein (2023)

deepfakes — and increasingly, influential figures recognise its potential to surpass human intelligence and even destroy civilization altogether.[31]

On the polycrisis account, like most rapidly adopted, disruptive technology, innovation is accelerating far more quickly than regulation can keep up, and different societies have very different appetites for regulation.

A metacrisis account locates the roots of the AI threat in the myth of progress, materialism, rationalist market fundamentalism and rivalrous individualism:

- Our faith in **material progress** has led to a deification of technology and institutionalised belief in its status as a human good, to the extent that its danger is not accounted for in our approaches to governance.
- The same **rationalist fundamentalism** described above trust the market to choose technology that will produce good outcomes.
- The same **collective action problem** that dampens global co-ordination around decarbonisation produces a race-to-the-bottom with dangerous technology. *If I don't invent it first, you will.*
- A pseudo-darwinian view of human nature accepts rivalrous tendencies as fundamental - an impoverished view that is incompatible with globalised access to radically destructive technologies.[32]

More quickly than climate breakdown, the prospect of exponential AI has pulled core paradigmatic assumptions into public consciousness and into doubt. Those innovators backpedalling at the precipice of exponential AI are witnessing first-hand the death of the modern myth of technological progress.

Case study 3: Populism and democratic backslide

[31] See e.g. Soros (2023)
[32] See e.g. Schmachtenberger (2023).

Populist politics rally support by casting 'the people' in opposition to a corrupt elite, usually in contexts of economic precarity and elite failure.[33] Within a polycrisis view, populist leaders exploit multiple crises[34] to grow support and challenge elite legitimacy, and even structures of democracy.[35] Meanwhile disruptive tech and fragmented media manufacture resentment and sow dis- and mis-information — all combining to generate a wider democratic crisis.

A metacrisis frame expands this view to include a deeper crisis of legitimacy in modern governance:

- Founded upon **technocratic rationality and secularism,** mainstream institutions within the modern liberal order fail to comprehend or address citizens' deeper need for meaning and community. Faith in institutions gradually breaks down amid a generalised atmosphere of cultural disenchantment. Meanwhile populism thrives on emotional, identity-driven narratives with deeper human resonance. Bureaucratic liberalism and technocracy struggle to compete.
- Like our economic model, simple democratic political models built on the assumption of **rational individualism** are not fit for purpose, particularly in an era of profound complexity and information overload, where private individuals cannot hope to comprehend the full implications of particular choices. At a time of epistemic confusion (driven in part by cultural fragmentation arising from postmodern value relativism (see appendix IV)), some political actors exploit weakened democratic principles to achieve power and further undermine democracy.
- Widespread polarisation of political views arises from the epistemic and cultural fragmentation of late (post-)modernity. With this fragmentation, comes a growing tendency to view political opposition as illegitimate, and populist executives foment and then exploit public appetite for weakening of constitutional checks and balances.[36]

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[33] E.g. Mudde & Kaltwasser (2017)
[34] Often arising from globalisation - see e.g. Helleiner (2024)
[35] See e.g. Tsagkroni (2024)
[36] See e.g. Russell et al (2022) and Benasaglio-Belluchi & Kelham (2023).

Table 1: Key issues compared in polycrisis and metacrisis frames		
Issue	Polycrisis frame	Metacrisis frame
Climate	An escalating crisis that interacts with others like energy and food insecurity, economic instability, and mass migration. Solutions demand a complex, intergovernmental effort to decarbonize energy systems while maintaining stability across these interconnected domains.	The consequence of a modern, reductive materialist worldview: treating nature as a machine, prioritizing economic / material growth over ecological limits, and assuming that harm can be 'externalised'. This fragmented perspective ablates wholeness and complexity, and dampens collective action, prioritising short-term, competition over long-term planetary well-being.
Populism	A reaction to economic precarity and elite failure, exacerbated by globalization, inequality, and disruptive media technologies. Polarization erodes trust in democracy and reinforces populist tendencies that undermine democratic norms and governance.	A deeper crisis of legitimacy in modern governance. Technocratic, secular rationalism fails to address people's need for meaning, while democratic models based on an outdated rational individualist model of human nature prove inadequate in an era of complexity. Populism offers emotionally charged, identity-driven alternatives to bureaucratic liberalism.
AI	AI's rapid acceleration outpaces regulation, creating risks ranging from deepfakes to existential threats. Societies differ in their regulatory approaches, exacerbating global coordination failures. Unchecked development of AI could destabilize economies, governance, and the information commons.	Modern deification of technology, rationalist market fundamentalism, and competitive individualism contribute to our AI crisis. A blind belief in progress prioritizes innovation over caution, while the mother of all collective action problems fuels a reckless race toward potentially catastrophic uses.

Why Seeing the Metacrisis Matters

Reckoning with modernity

"It's been the end of the world for someone, all along"

- Leanne Betasamosake Simpson[37]

The tendency of modern science and industry to yield extraordinary material progress and power for many has led to globalised dominance of the foundational modern worldview. Conversely, it would be inaccurate to suggest that following centuries of perfect good health, the world suddenly got sick - or even just exhausted. The metacrisis has existed for as long as the modern paradigm - latent in some parts of the gradually globalising system that produced it, blatant in others. From genocide to slavery, poverty, industrial drudgery and extractive ecosystem destruction, the living cost of modernity's advances has always been felt somewhere.

Nonetheless for a great many, insulated from most symptoms of the metacrisis for much of our lives, modernity has been 'the water we swim in'. Naturally, from within any uninterrogated worldview, the suggestion that it isn't absolute invites profound cognitive dissonance. Furthermore, when a worldview has been shared by a majority for centuries, social norms maintain it, and challenge can risk ridicule.

Precisely because of its foundational nature however, our cultural paradigm represents a vital point of departure for response to interconnected global crises. Donella Meadows, a founding member of the Club of Rome and author of *The Limits to Growth*[38] introduced the language of 'leverage points' to describe the places within a system where "a small shift in one thing can produce a big shift in everything". As such, she identifies the mindsets and paradigms that shape societal systems as the deepest leverage point for system change.[39]

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[37] Simpson (2017)

[38] Meadows (1972)

[39] Meadows (1999)

Doorways to a metacrisis view

Only after we intuit the real nature of society's illness, can we even begin to redirect our vast collective energies to healing it. To this end, a shift from polycrisis to metacrisis thinking would be a most valuable start. But *for people rooted cognitively in the modern paradigm,* this shift is itself tantamount to adopting a new way of looking at the world. To recognise our worldview for what it is, is already somewhat to leave it behind - or at least to understand that it is partial, and not ultimate. Typically, this is not the kind of shift that occurs only because we learned new facts, but results from some experience or practice that has loosened our earlier way of looking.

For example, some people gain insight through meditation practice that dismantles the self view and the story of separateness, revealing the deep interconnection of the world. Others gain similar insights through exploration of plant medicines and other psychedelics. Sometimes, an acute trauma or a serious brush with mortality disrupts life-as-usual and calls into question everything we once thought true or unchanging. And throughout our own lifetimes, amid the gathering storm of the polycrisis, more and more people are picking up the long-term signal that *something is seriously wrong* within the dominant system.

Those inclined to a flexible view — dispositionally or by force of events — may also engage with an evolving branch of social philosophy and meta-theory dedicated to paradigm shift. From Integral Theory to Metamodernism, the Sense-Making Web and more, a growing body of work aims at understanding the metacrisis and cultivating wise foundations for a future world.

It would not be wholly accurate to describe these branches of thought as 'new'. Above we mention 'people rooted cognitively in the modern paradigm' - and needless to say this is not all people. The wisdom held within ancient traditions that have survived or adapted to modern conditions is a crucial influence on these new areas of enquiry; and the leading critiques of modernity found here and elsewhere have roots in indigenous perspectives. Leading proposals for new paradigm thinking

often integrate premodern spiritual practices with modern scientific paradigms such as complexity theory and neuroscience.[40]

To embed new ways of looking is often a matter of combining several of the above factors over time. Insights arising through intense experiences often do not last, and require integration through praxis and even deliberate lifestyle shift. Contemplative practitioners emphasize the difference between (mental) state and *trait*. This journey from experiencing a kind of perspective to an embodied tendency is best supported through sustained relationship with like-minded others: shifting worldviews is a matter of community.

Reshaping the onward path

Without perceiving their origins, it's unsurprising that we sometimes feel powerless to intervene adequately in our crises. However, it would be misleading to suggest that, armed with the idea of root causes, our institutions will suddenly solve all our problems. Even the language of problem and solution limits us to a modern 'managerial' view of the world.[41] We are beyond 'solutions' that will restore business as usual. We won't address current crises through the logic and value systems that created them - or the institutions that seek to maintain them.[42]

Nonetheless, 'metacrisis' as a frame for our times does not leave us at an impasse. While we may not derive from our diagnosis a neat roadmap for action, we can identify a place to start — a way of thinking and being that can underpin wiser, healthier relationship with ourselves and the world. The only viable future society will be built on life-respecting principles - and in the meantime, the approaches that succeed in limiting harm will need to confront the reductive modern logic that led us here, instead prioritising interdependency, wholeness, and cultivation of the neglected inner world.

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[40] For example, the work of John Vervaeke,Brendan Graham Dempsey, Ken Wilber and Iain McGilchrist

[41] See e.g. Rowson (2023) (2)

[42] See e.g. Debold / Stein (2022)

Towards such a future, a polycrisis view helps us to identify the cracks in our systems. The metacrisis view is where we begin to reimagine their foundations.

Further reading

The danger of a 'basic' introduction to a subject like metacrisis is the loss of nuance that is important to a full understanding. A growing body of literature develops metacrisis theory in depth and we hope that readers will wish to know more. The following content may support your exploration:

Video content

Jonathan Rowson: Living in the Metacrisis
Daniel Schmachtenberger: An introduction to the Metacrisis
Zak Stein / Rufus Pollock: Beyond the Metacrisis
Bayo Akomolafe / Jeremy Lent: Modernity has Expired. What Comes Next?
John Vervaeke Iain McGilchrist Daniel Schmachtenberger: The Psychological Drivers of the Metacrisis
A Revolution in Thought? - Dr Iain McGilchrist

Essays and interviews

Anthea Lawson / Anywhere but Here
Jonathan Rowson / Prefixing the World
Joana Breidenbach/ The Metacrisis Or what future paths are open to us?
Jamie Bristow, Rosie Bell, Christine Wamsler, Tomas Björkman, Phoebe Tickell, Julia Kim and Otto Scharmer / The System Within
Paul Kingsnorth / The Myth of Progress

Books

*Ken Wilber / **Sex, Ecology, Spirituality: The Spirit of Evolution.***
*Thomas Bjorkman / **The World We Create***
*Iain McGilchrist / **The Master and His Emissary***
*Vanessa Machado de Oliveira / **Hospicing Modernity***

Advanced texts

*Iain McGilchrist / **The Matter with Things: Our Brains, Our Delusions, and the Unmaking of the World** (2021)*

Jonathan Rowson, Layman Pascal, Zak Stein, Bonnitta Roy, Daniel Gortz (Hanzi Freinacht), Lene Rachel Andersen, Sarah Stein Lubrano, Minna Salami, John Vervaeke, Christopher Mastropietro, Tom Murray, Mark Vernon, Jonathan Jong, Siva Thambisetty, Brent Cooper / ***Dispatches from a Time Between Worlds: Crisis and Emergence in Metamodernity.***

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Appendices

Appendix I: Describing the metacrisis: leading accounts in quotes

The term metacrisis has a long lineage, but its current sense is quite recent, forming over the last decade. Being emergent, the term is still variously used – this essay is in part an attempt to provide a distilled definition – one we hope consonant with existing efforts while clarifying certain elements - in particular the relationship to root causes within the cultural paradigm.

Within the emerging discourse of metacrisis, different schools of thought are concerned with 'meta' issues at varying depth.[43] Below are a number of leading definitions of the term.

Jonathan Rowson

"The metacrisis is the historically specific threat to truth, beauty, and goodness caused by our persistent misunderstanding, misvaluing, and misappropriating of reality. The metacrisis is the crisis within and between all the world's major crises, a root cause that is at once singular and plural, a multi-faceted delusion arising from the spiritual and material exhaustion of modernity that permeates the world's interrelated challenges and manifests institutionally and culturally to the detriment of life on earth."[44]

Approach: metacrisis demands transformation at the interacting levels of souls, society and systems i.e. all three 'layers'.

Nicholas Hedlund

"The metacrisis is a complex, multifaceted gestalt or "laminated system." Interacting eco-social, ethical and existential crises are compounded by a radically disorienting epistemic crisis— our sense-making apparatus is shattered, partly by this very

[43] Appendix I offers a more detailed genealogy of the term 'metacrisis' in recent use

[44] Rowson (2023)

complexity and also by issues of fragmentation and 'post-truth' atrophy of the public sphere. These crises have roots in "the philosophical, scientific, cultural, psychological, and spiritual structures in the vital dynamism of the lifeworld (lebenswelt)... a vision of the world and humanity's place in it—a worldview (weltanschauung), collective self-understanding, or overarching metatheory.[45]

Approach: coherent, metaexplanatory theory of the underlying structural drivers of crises: integrative, realist, emancipatory and visionary - intervention primarily at the root layer.

Daniel Schmachtenberger

"All (human induced) existential and catastrophic risks are symptoms of two underlying generator functions:[46]

1. *Rivalrous (win-lose) games multiplied by exponential technology self terminate.*
2. *Complicated systems subsuming their complex substrate, becoming increasingly fragile till collapse becomes immanent."*[47]

Approach: solve collective action problems and learn to build sustainable 'closed loop' systems in harmony with complex systems: i.e. intermediate and surface layers.

Zak Stein

"The metacrisis... has to do with how humans understand themselves and the world... systems and societies are in trouble, but it is the psyche that is in the direst of straits."[48]
"foundationally a crisis at the root of the way we make choices about civilisation itself... the very source code... of how civilisations are designed...and maintained."[49]

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[45] Hedlund (2023), developing Hedlund (2016)
[46] Elsewhere frequently equated with metacrisis
[47] Schmachtenberger (2017) (and others - see other citations in the bibliography)
[48] Stein (2022)
[49] Stein et al. (2023)

Approach: Reimagined education, oriented around a new metaphysical framework of shared truth and value, cultivating mature humans capable of navigating complexity. Foundational philosophical work; a world philosophy adequate to a sustainable civilisation. Root and intermediate layers.

Appendix II: **Metacrisis: an incomplete genealogy**

Throughout the recent decade, the concept of metacrisis has developed steadily, and the term has grown in popularity. With thanks to Jonah Wilberg for his research, the timeline below plots key developments - asking forgiveness from the many thinkers in the related ecosystem whose contribution is missing or truncated.

Deep Antecedents (**Pre-2010s**)

Marxist Tradition (**19th–20th c.**): Karl Marx theorised economic structures as underlying multiple crises—an early "meta-crisis" concept (though not named so). Gramsci's "organic crisis," Althusser's ideology, and Habermas's *legitimation crisis* broadened this toward cultural-political dimensions.

Phenomenological/Cultural Tradition (**19th–20th c.**): Nietzsche (nihilism), Spengler (*Decline of the West*), Husserl (*Crisis of the European Sciences*), Heidegger (*Question Concerning Technology*), Adorno, Jonas — all frame civilizational breakdown as cultural or ontological crisis, often linked to technological modernity.

Consciousness Evolution tradition: writers like Sri Aurobindo and Jean Gebser develop the idea of major shifts in human consciousness and worldview and their association with critical points in human history. This work is later directly influential on Ken Wilber and the Integral movement.

Club of Rome (**1972**) ***Limits to Growth***: Used terms like "meta-problem" or "meta-system of problems" (Rowson cites this as proto-metacrisis).

Donella Meadows (**1999**) ***Leverage Points:*** A founding member of the Club of Rome, Donella Meadows ranked systems change interventions in terms of effectiveness - the deepest leverage point is the mindset or worldview from which the system arises.[50]

Early Explicit Uses of *Metacrisis:* Lane & Van der Leeuw (**2011**)
Early paper using *metacrisis* in the context of technological innovation policy—highlighting systemic challenges of innovation governance.

Theoretical roots Rowson (**2014, *Spiritualise***) *"many seem to recognise that the world's major problems have 'spiritual' elements that are not adequately acknowledged or addressed, partly because we don't seem to know how to conduct the debate at that kind of fundamental level.*

2015–2016: Term begins appearing in forms closer to today's sense.

Nicholas Hedlund & Sean Esbjörn-Hargens

Influenced by Roy Bhaskar's Critical Realism and Ken Wilber's Integral Theory, the 2015 conference *Metatheory for the 21st Century* brought *metacrisis* into academic-metatheoretical discourse.

"I coined the notion of metacrisis with Sean Esbjörn-Hargens in 2015 (Hedlund et al., 2016) to express the complex unity or concatenated nature of our twenty-first century planetary crises, due to their systemic nature and overlapping root causes…our introduction was shared

[50] Meadows (1999)

with the participants of the Critical Realism & Integral Theory Symposium… and had already made its way into the discourse at the 2015 Integral Theory Conference."[51]

It's possible to discern the views commonly associated with the term more generally, within the earlier work of Hedlund & Esbjörn-Hargens:

1. Metacrisis as polycrisis (multiplicity of global crises), plus:
2. Crises share root causes
3. Inner, psychological and cultural roots
4. Epistemological crisis: wicked complexity resists our ability to even perceive it; compounding polycrisis symptoms reciprocally.

2. Theological/Political Tradition

E.g. Milbank & Pabst, The Politics of Virtue (2016):

The authors speak of a "liberal metacrisis;" tracing modern crises to ***liberal individualism****, advocating pre-modern communal ethics and virtue. Christian-theological in lineage, but overlaps thematically with Integral/Critical Realist framings (cultural/ethical breakdown at root of crises).*

2017 onwards: theoretical development by:

Jonathan Rowson (Perspectiva)

Frames the "crisis driving the crises" as a crisis of value, meaning, and perception (truth, beauty, goodness), arising from our deepest cultural understanding of reality. He parses the metacrisis into **socio-emotional** (the crisis of *We*/belonging), **educational** (global *paideia*/Bildung deficits), **epistemic** (information ecology, legitimacy, sensemaking), and **spiritual**.[52]

[51] Hedlund (2023)
[52] Rowson (2021)

Zak Stein

Initially: *"What is called the metacrisis is, in truth, an educational crisis:* ***our collective incapacity to bring forth mature adults capable of holding, making sense of, and acting within the unprecedented complexity of our planetary situation.****"*[53] Later: Broadened to a *civilizational "crisis of the mind,"*[54] retaining education as the key leverage point, and *"The metacrisis is a profound misunderstanding of the nature of of what is valuable."*[55]

Iain McGilchrist locates metacrisis in worldview and links with hemispheric theory. Metacrisis roots lie in a dominant mode of thinking shaped by left-hemisphere cognition—analytical, reductionist, mechanistic—while the right hemisphere, with its holistic, relational, context-sensitive mode, has been marginalized.
"…these crises are not merely adventitiously interrelated … but because they share roots at a deeper level…both in the psyche of the individual and that of a civilisation viewed as a whole."

Daniel Schmachtenberger

Key figure in popularising metacrisis as a term. Frames metacrisis through **generator functions**: Rivalrous economic/game-theoretic incentive structures (multipolar traps), exponential technological power, fragile complicated systems dependent on complex living systems, polluted information ecology. **Emphasis on existential risk and coordination failure.**

Throughout this period, authors like Tomas Bjorkman, Indra Adnan, Iain Mcgilchrist, Vanessa Machado de Oliveira, Jeremy Lent, John Vervaeke and many more are developing similar themes (identifying cultural/spiritual roots of widespread crisis) without necessarily using the term metacrisis or the framing represented here.

[53] Stein (2019)
[54] Stein (2023)
[55] Stein (2024)

Popularisation (2017–2020)

Metacrisis spreads throughout 'metamodern intellectual niches - Game B, Integral theory, metamodernism. Podcasts and YouTube channels first to engage with this model of the meta-crisis included Emerge, Rebel Wisdom, the Jim Rutt Show, the Stoa, The Side View, State of Emergence, Parallax, the Dark Horse, Collective Insights, Future Fossils, Mutations, and Future Thinkers[56]

Recent formulations

2023 Nicholas Hedlund *Visionary Realism in a Time of Metacrisis* PhD thesis develops a rigorous academic metatheory integrating Critical Realism & Integral Theory.

(See also appendix VI.) Hedlund's model of metacrisis *itself* does not explicitly include worldview or cultural paradigm but concentrates on a 'laminate' crisis correlating mostly with what we have called the 'intermediate layer.' Nonetheless this recent work explicitly grounds metacrisis approaches in metatheory as *"deep causal codes or architectonic generator functions of our worldviews and thus our socio-political order".*

2023 Jonathan Rowson develops work on the relationship of polycrisis to metacrisis, arriving at a new definition:

"The metacrisis is the historically specific threat to truth, beauty, and goodness caused by our persistent misunderstanding, misvaluing, and misappropriating of reality. The metacrisis is the crisis within and between all the world's major crises, a root cause that is at once singular and plural, a multi-faceted delusion arising from the spiritual and material exhaustion of modernity that permeates the world's interrelated challenges and manifests institutionally and culturally to the detriment of life on earth."

[56] Hedlund (2021)

2023 Life Itself offers a distilled account of the polycrisis / metacrisis relationship with the launch of the *Second Renaissance* initiative, synthesising prior research within the Integral Tradition (Ken Wilber et al.) alongside more explicit theorists of the metacrisis.

Appendix III: Ideological features of modernity

The **modern** era is considered properly to have begun during the 15th century; distilled throughout centuries of rapid **scientific and technological progress** and **secular liberalism** into the dominant cultural paradigm still operating globally today. An evolving set of interrelated core views and values was coextensive with scientific, industrial and cultural development throughout the modern era, and some are laid out below. While this analysis may seem to suggest modernity as a list of separate things, these pieces are better understood as a family of closely related stories. Not all *originate* in modernity - rather most were developed, amplified and embedded within the modern paradigm and the culture it engendered.

Empiricism: the belief that sensory experience is the only trustworthy basis for confirming knowledge about the external world. The foundation of experimental scientific method, among its chief advocated in the 17th and 18th centuries were John Locke, George Berkeley, and David Hume.

Scientific Materialism: the related view that nothing exists except physical matter, subject to particular laws of physics (as opposed to e.g. divine nature).

Reductionism(/**atomism**)**:** the view that in this purely physical world, all phenomena can be properly explained as the sum interaction of simpler phenomena, and that the smallest parts are the fundamental units of reality.

Mechanistic view: as innovation in mechanics spread (and arguably since the clock was invented) a root metaphor of nature-as-machine supplanted metaphors like

nature-as-nurturing-parent in the public imaginary. A corresponding view of creator god as the 'divine clockmaker' allowed religious belief to co-exist with the mechanistic view.

Newtonian mechanics: (functional but partial) early mathematical laws of physics explaining motion of material objects

Darwinian evolution: the idea that species change over time, give rise to new species through natural selection, and share a common ancestor.

Objective truth: the view that in our absolute, physical world, there is truth about the way things are, independent of human perception. An objective, constant, external universe.

Substance Dualism: a view Advanced by Descartes, somewhat reactionary to burgeoning materialism, that mental phenomena are not properly part of the physical world.

Rationalism: elevates the faculty for reason and logic as the ultimate source of knowledge in contrast to e.g. *emotion* or faith (Descartes: "I think, therefore I am"). Partially complementary to empiricism in that rational truths are known 'a priori', independently of 'a posteriori' sense experience, and that reason is typically instrumental in arriving at empirical facts.

Individualism was linked closely to rationalism, and the idea that an individual faculty of reason is the route to truth. As religious influence faded over centuries, expression of individual character and pursuit of individual goals (contra pre-modern conformity) became a paramount cultural value. Self-determination is closely linked to notions of freedom and equality - in Enlightenment thought, *individual* freedom is what matters.

Progress: The idea that human society and the individual should advance / improve towards a desirable goal. As secularism replaced religious goals, ideas of progress took on material and scientific values.

Conquering nature: The idea of man's innate right to dominion over nature has biblical roots, but saw a resurgence during the Enlightenment, particularly through the tracts of Francis Bacon.

Equality: Not least through a series of political revolutions, arbitrary authority (royalty, feudalism) was fundamentally challenged during the Enlightenment period. Locke argued that "all men were created equal and that no one should be born into more power than another" - however in practice, equality as a cultural value took centuries to develop towards its imperfect expression in today's late Modern society. (Some have argued that equality became an 'Enlightenment' value partly via indigenous critique of colonial behaviours.[57] Certainly, European notions of equality did not extend to the populations of colonised nations throughout the modern era.)

Freedom (**of thought/conscience**) was another revolutionary ideal that took root during the Enlightenment, challenging religious dogma as a route to truth and knowledge. Locke linked freedom closely with rationality: "we are born free as we are born rational". If knowledge comes only from reason, we require freedom of thought to arrive at knowledge.

Appendix IV: Metacrisis to polycrisis mapping

Metacrisis foundation	**Modern traits / attitudes**	**Contributes to (Polycrisis Symptoms)**
Materialism: the primary locus of reality is physical	Capitalist preoccupation with economic growth, signified by goods produced,	Addiction to fossil fuels Tech solutionism

[57] E.g. Graeber & Wengrow (2021)

matter.	bought and sold. Deifying science and technology; preoccupation with material progress Decline in importance of non-material (particularly spiritual) value. Neglect or disdain for human inner dimensions and capacities. Desacralising and dominating nature	Inequality Consumerism Meaning crisis Mental health crisis Incomplete (externally focused) understanding of multiple crises
Empiricism: the primary basis of knowledge (and power) in the world is material evidence gathered through **measurement.**	Fixation with measurement and quantity as the primary gauge of value. Pursuit of GDP as measure of societal success. Neglect of unmeasurable value as unreal or trivial.	Extractive economic activity that destroys complex, ecological value in pursuit of abstract value (money). Economic fragility, volatility and unsustainability
Rationalism: human beings are fundamentally rational agents acting in their own best interest.	Poor understanding of complex emotional motivations and human vulnerabilities. Trust in 'the market' to deliver best outcomes as a proxy for rational human choice. Technocratic institutions	Runaway consumerism and ecological destruction. Runaway tech Inequality Crisis of legitimacy; populism
Reductionism: all systems are best understood as the sum of separate parts, and the smallest parts are fundamental.	Neglect of systemic interactions; Administration of human systems in institutional silos, neglect of interdependencies. Understanding of complex living systems as if they were merely	Ecological destruction legitimised as 'externality' Failure to anticipate non-linear climate impacts Poor preparation for cascading

	complicated machines.	systems impacts
Separateness / atomism: understanding of humans as individual units, fundamentally separate from others and nature.	Failure to comprehend relationship of interdependency with others and nature View of nature as an external resource	Exploitation Colonialism Alienation and mental health crises Consumerism Inequality Tech 'race to the bottom' Difficulty cutting emissions Protectionism Authoritarianism Conflict Social fragmentation Meaning crisis
Individualism: individual as the basic unit of humanity.	Personal success prioritised and rewarded over collective care.	
Competition, selfish gene: Human nature as fundamentally competitive. Darwinian 'survival of the fittest' as a principal of evolutionary success.	Species, racial and national chauvinism Collective action problems Poor understanding (and low deployment) of pro-social capacities as foundation for societal flourishing	
Myth of progress: the evolution of human society is a process of inevitable improvement. Progress, especially, material progress is a human good.	Bias towards facilitating and/or accelerating progress, innovation, invention - material in particular.	Escalating tech Climate breakdown Tech solutionism

Appendix V: Navigating paradigm shifts by features

Shifts in different features happen at different rates, and in different demographics. For example, across history it's possible to see **art** taking the lead in expressing emerging paradigms. The perspectival / realist revolution in art that characterised the Renaissance emerged in Europe as early as the early 1300s in the work of Giotto. What we typically call modern art tends often to exhibit postmodern principles - for example, Picasso's rendering of multiple, simultaneous perspectives, Dali's surrealist questioning of rational boundaries, and Duchamp's relativist challenge to the establishment of art itself.

Cimabue c.1280: pre-perspective

Perugino, 1481: linear perspective

Picasso 1937: plural perspective

Observable paradigm shifts in philosophy and social movements often move in parallel with art, then afterwards, business, politics, mainstream society and so on. This staggered adoption gives rise to an (often uneasy) blend of paradigms operating in societies. For example, right now in the United States, while leading-edge art is arguably dabbling in a metamodern phase (consider films such as Everything, Everywhere All At Once) much popular culture exhibits post-modern traits - fragmented, media-driven and hyperreal - and elite institutions like universities and some media are largely postmodern, while economics remains anchored in the modern, and large parts of the population still operate pre-modern, religious views. Significant friction arises from the coexistence of multiple paradigms, playing into the political instability of our times.

Appendix VI: Culture wars and metacrisis

'Culture war' is a familiar feature of our late (post)modern times: social tensions rise as political attitudes polarise away from the center, towards ideological extremes.[58]

[58] ECPS (2025)

Inasmuch as culture wars are considered a crisis, our current metacrisis frame is insufficient to account for underlying polarisation in the same way as e.g. climate. While features of modernity have played a part, the cultural fragmentation of our times may be better understood as a feature of a time *between* paradigms: a breakdown at the level of our collective worldview.

The escalating hyper-individualism and secular materialism of modernity *has* eroded collective meaning. More fundamentally however, as modern cultural hegemony declines, the discourses of several cultural paradigms are clashing:

- **Pre-modernity** (traditional, religious, communitarian) is residual and resurgent
- **Modernity** (liberal democracy, scientism, rationalism, technocracy) struggles to maintain legitimacy and coherence
- **Postmodernity** critiques and deconstructs modernity but offers no clear replacement

The current intense conflict between cultural factions feels intractable precisely because the 'opinions' at stake go all the way to our interpretation of reality itself. Many well-intended interventions (e.g., tech regulation, media literacy) fail because they don't account for the deep epistemic and cultural fragmentation underlying polarization.

Appendix VII: Hedlund's map of the Metacrisis

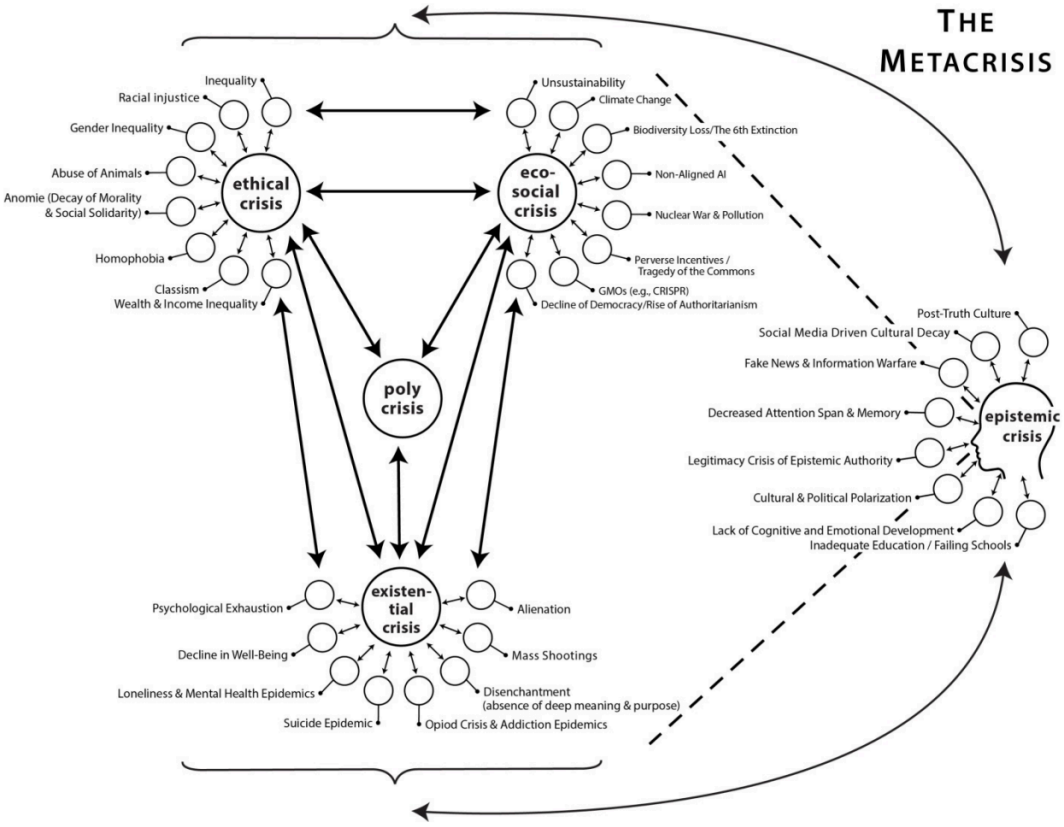
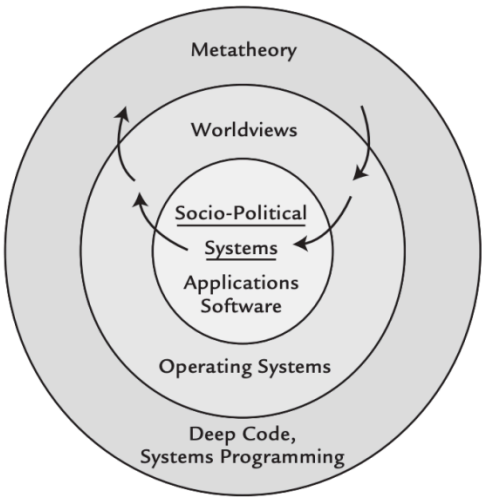


Figure 1: The Metacrisis



Two diagrams from Hedlund (2023) illustrate his model of the metacrisis and its relationship with worldview and metatheory. In contrast, this essay defines metacrisis as having its source *at the level of worldview and metatheory* (i.e. cultural paradigm).